

CITIZEN DIPLOMACY: A STRATEGY FOR PROMOTING MUTUAL ECONOMIC AND CULTURAL COOPERATION BETWEEN IRAN AND AFRICA

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Abstract

Many countries in Africa, Asia and Latin America that can be described as transitional democracies are bedevilled with myriad development challenges ranging from political instability, official corruption, high rate of unemployment, disturbing levels of poverty, low standard of living, high illiteracy rates, etc. however, most of these challenges have largely persisted in many African countries including Nigeria, due to the twin challenge of existing weak (governance) institutions that have over the years, been unable to effectively address these development challenges in a sustainable manner; as well as the observable dearth of political will on the part of the governing elite to strengthen these weak institutions with a view to turn around the fortunes and the lot of their citizens for the better. It is against this backdrop that this paper advocates citizen diplomacy as a viable strategy for the promotion of mutual economic and cultural cooperation between Africa and Iran in a bid to collectively harness and deploy the massive untapped economic and cultural potential in Africa for the benefit of the citizens of Africa and Iran through a coordinated development-oriented albeit informal partnerships among and between the citizens of the Iran and Africa. To achieve this, the data for this study was generated from secondary sources documentary reviews and the data was analysed using qualitative method of analysis. The study reveals that challenges such as official corruption, lack of strong institutions, lack of political will etc. constitute some of the bottlenecks inhibiting progressive reforms that would engender socio-economic development in most African countries including Nigeria. The study therefore advocates mutually beneficial but informal citizen-to-citizen economic and cultural partnerships between citizens of Iran and Africa with a view to collectively harness the massive untapped economic and cultural potentials in African for the benefit of all.

Key words: Citizen Diplomacy, Transitional Democracy, Political Will, Economic and Cultural Cooperation.